need to have an actor who exuded charm but also one who came with "a certain fading, decaying quality". "In his own way, he had lived both parts of his life already on the grand cinematic journey that he has been on," says Behl of Roy. "He knew many sides of the character already in an experiential manner."

Agra's journey to the Croisette has come after much struggle for Behl. After securing 40 per cent funding from France's 'Cinema du Monde' film fund in 2017, it took him another two years to find an Indian producer. "Structural support for contemporary art house voices", as he notes, isn't

AFTER SECURING 40 PER CENT FUNDING FROM FRANCE'S 'CINEMA DU MONDE', IT TOOK BEHL ANOTHER TWO YEARS TO FIND AN INDIAN PRODUCER

the easiest to find in India. It came in the form of Saregama's Yoodlee Films. For co-producer Siddharth Anand Kumar, backing auteur-driven cinema is part of the studio's vision. "There are some directors who know what they want and don't waver from their vision. Luckily, for him, that vision is intact," says Kumar. Now, just as Yoodlee empowered him, Behl hopes to reach a position where he can extend the same backing to other ingenious voices. He set up 028 Films to do just that. Says Behl, "I never stop hoping and fighting." ■

Suhani Singh

CINEMA

NYIFF BACK IN CINEMAS

The New York Indian Film Festival is back and ready to kick off in cinemas after three digital editions

Considered North America's longest-running and most prestigious Indian film festival, the 23rd edition of the New York Indian Film Festival (NYIFF) is being held **from May 11-14, 2023**, and will include over 30 narratives, documentaries and shorts, with a special New York screening of Rahul Chittella's critically-acclaimed *Gulmohar* (2023) on May 12.

Actors Manoj Bajpayee, Sharmila Tagore, Kalki Koechlin and Shefali Shah are slated to make appearances at the festival. While Shah stars as the lead in the opening film of the gala, Avinash Arun's *Three of Us* (2022), Koechlin and Deepti Naval's *Goldfish* (2022) will bring down the curtain on the festival. The opening night will be held at Village East by Angelika and the closing night at SVA Theatre, which will also include the much-anticipated NYIFF Awards.

Radhika Madan has been nominated for the Best Actress award for *Sanaa* (2022). She will be vying for top honours in the category with Koechlin, Naval, Shah and Nimisha Sajayan (for the upcoming film *Footprints on Water*). *Sanaa*, a social drama by National Award-winning director Sudhanshu Saria, has already garnered critical acclaim and was the sole Indian film to have premiered at the 26th Tallinn Black Nights Film Festival and the 38th Santa Barbara International Film Festival recently. The Anupam Kher-starrer short film, *Retake*, an introspective story exploring themes of love and loss, will premiere at the NYIFF on May 13 and has also been nominated for an award.

"We are thrilled to witness the global recognition of Indian cinema with not just one but three Indian films acknowledged at the Oscars. The milestone highlights incredible talent and diversity of Indian cinema, and we are honoured to showcase some of the best works of Indian filmmakers to our audience," said Suman Gollamudi, the executive director for the Indo-American Arts Council, which runs the NYIFF, in a press release. Gollamudi, of course, references the Oscar-winning Documentary Short *The Elephant Whisperers* (2022), the award-winning Best Original Song 'Naatu Naatu' from *RRR* (2022), and the Best Documentary Feature-nominated *All That Breathes* (2022).

NYIFF festival director Aseem Chhabra added, "The mission of NYIFF has and will always be to elevate the very best of filmmakers and storytellers featuring India and its culture." ■

Sharmistha Chaudhuri

THE INDIAN CHARM
(Clockwise from right) still from *Retake* (upcoming), *Sanaa* (2022), *Footprints on Water* (upcoming) and *Three of Us* (2022)







